



CHEQUERED FLAG

THE PERFECT HOMECOMING

Charles Leclerc ended his Monaco Grand Prix curse with a **commanding home victory**, while Max Verstappen struggled with pace to settle for seventh position.

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Every elite athlete across sports wants to be at their best on home soil. Most try to push that extra bit to raise their levels, egged on by a partisan audience. Some even reserve their best for their home event.

For Ferrari's Charles Leclerc, his home race is extra special. The Monaco Grand Prix is considered a crown jewel event on the F1 calendar, and every driver wants to win it mainly for two reasons.

One, it is a challenging track around the narrow streets of Monte Carlo, where the margin of error is so tiny that one small mistake could mean the driver hits the wall, which could spoil the whole weekend. Add to it the sheer razzmatazz surrounding the event, with opulent parties and celebrities from royalty to Hollywood stars adding sheen to the occasion.

For Leclerc, as the only Monegasque driver on the grid, there are sky-high expectations whenever the F1 circus visits the Principality. However, the 26-year-old has had a mixed record at the famed venue.

Despite taking two pole positions on a track where qualifying virtually decides the final finishing position, Leclerc hadn't even been on the podium.

In 2021, he couldn't start the race after a driveshaft broke just before the start of the race following his crash during qualifying. In 2022, a strategic blunder by Ferrari saw him go from leading the race to finishing fourth.

This time, Leclerc finally broke his home-race curse, converting his third pole position to a lights-to-flag victory to claim his sixth Grand Prix win and first since 2022.

Right from the free practice sessions on Friday, Leclerc and Ferrari looked mighty impressive on a weekend when Max Verstappen was surprisingly way off pace. The Red Bull struggled with

Local hero: Leclerc comfortably led Oscar Piastri and his teammate Carlos Sainz to a famous victory in his backyard. GETTY IMAGES